

directly using a telephone line. In this case, instead of you and your friend dialling out using two different telephone lines to connect to each other via the Internet, you use just one telephone line to dial straight to your friend. This cuts down phone bills by half.

Alternatively, if you and your friend stay within 150 metres from each other, consider using a cross-over cable. Beyond that you will have to make use of repeaters and you need to find a feasible intermediate location to attach the same. You will have to spend around Rs 900 for two LAN cards, about Rs 800 per repeater and Rs 10 per metre of cables used.

Opt for an 'Always On' service provider if your locality has one. These connect PCs to a small network and thereby provide Internet access to the PCs. In this way you could get connected on a LAN and then play games.

Another alternative is to set up a Wi-Fi network but this is possible if you and your friend stay in line of sight. This solution also depends on a lot of environmental factors. Typically, you will need a wireless LAN card plus a couple of high-gain antennas. You could buy a high gain antenna or make one yourself. You will find lot of stuff on the Internet in this regard. The total cost of this solution should be around Rs 15,000.

A VGA compatibility issue

Q. I have a Pentium 4 1.6 GHz CPU and a VIA motherboard. Now, I wish to upgrade

the VGA card, but I don't know which one to opt for? My friend also has a VIA motherboard and a GeForce4, but it causes a lot of problems while playing games. My dealer recommends the Max Force GeForce4; should I buy that?

Rohit Singh

A Yes, there are a lot of issues with the VIA motherboard and the GeForce4, so before buying beware. To counter the problems that arise, you need to constantly look out for BIOS and motherboard updates and install them as soon as they are released. If possible, get the motherboard replaced and then think of buying a new VGA card.

DAT, .INI and .DLL

Q. Of late, I've been facing several problems. My configuration is a Celeron 466, 128 MB of RAM, an 8.4 GB hard disk, and Windows 2000 Professional. Here's what's been happening:

I can't play .DAT files off my CD-ROM. They run from disk, though. I tried re-installing Windows but it didn't work.

I can't find the boot.ini file on my hard disk. I'm able to open it in Notepad, but after I'm not able to save it after modifying it it says that I "need to change the Read-only Attribute." In order to do this, I do a search for the file, but it doesn't show up in the results.

On a system with a VIA chipset Trident motherboard, 128 MB of RAM, a 20 GB hard disk, and a P-III 1GHz, I'm not able to install three OSes. I have three partitions

a 5 GB, another 5 GB and a 10 GB. On the first I have Windows 98, the second one is for Red Hat Linux 9, and the last is for XP. Without Linux, the other OSes used to run fine, but after installing Linux, when I try to boot into XP I get this message: "HAL.DLL is missing or corrupted." I tried the SFC on Windows 98, found the HAL.dll file, and extracted it from my XP CD to put it in the proper location, but it didn't work. Any answers?

Mayukh Chowdhury

A If you are able to copy the .DAT movie file from a VCD to your hard disk and play it, the problem is clearly hardware related. Older CD-ROM drives may have problems reading non-original CDs properly. The drive must retry reading multiple times before it picks up error-free data. This means that the data flow is slowed, and the drive may get very hot. To play back a movie smoothly, data flow should not be interrupted in this manner. You may try a "Lens Cleaner" CD, but in all probability this problem will only be fixed by a new CD Drive.

There's no doubt that your boot.ini file is in C:\. You can't find it because it's hidden, and you can't save it because it's read-only. To view hidden files, start Windows Explorer, and go to **Tools > Folder Options > View**. Select 'Show hidden files and folders.' Now you'll be able to see the boot.ini file. Select the file, right-click it, and choose Properties. Here, unselect 'Read-only' and click OK. Now you'll be able to modify the file as well.

To recover the HAL.dll file, boot from your Windows CD and choose the 'Repair' option. This will prompt you for the Windows installation to use. Supply the Administrator password, and you'll be able to restore any file you want to. Now, execute the following command at the prompt:

expand x:\i386\hal.dll y:\windows\system32\hal.dll. Replace 'x' with the drive letter of your CD-ROM, and 'y' with the letter of your Windows XP partition. Restart the machine, and you'll be able to boot into XP.

Norton error

Q. Whenever I install Norton AntiVirus 2004 Professional on either Windows Me or Windows XP, I get an error message saying "Norton antivirus has encountered an internal program error (4002,517)". I downloaded the 15-day trial program from

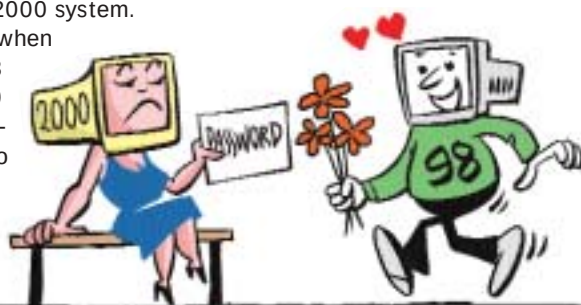
Negotiations between 98 and 2000

Q. I have set up two Windows 2000 Professional PCs and two Windows 98 PCs on a LAN. I am asked for a username and password while connecting from a 98 machine to a 2000 system. This does not happen when accessing the Windows 98 PCs from a Windows 2000 PC. How do I get the Windows 98 computers to access the Windows 2000 computers?

Ashtosh Chatterjee

A Create a user account on both the

2000 computers and specify a password for each. To do so, go to Control Panel and click on 'Users and Passwords', to add new users. Use these accounts to connect from the Windows 98 system.



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